

Session 14: The Oppression of Hagar

Key Takeaways

- In tragic irony, Avram and Sarai's oppression of Hagar, whose name means "the immigrant," comes right after God tells Avram that his descendants will be oppressed immigrants.
- Sarai's desire to be "built up" through Hagar is a distorted echo of God "building" the woman in Genesis 2.
- The text links Avram and Sarai's actions to the failure narratives of Genesis 3, 4, and 6.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 16:1-16

a ¹ Now, **Sarai the wife of Avram** had not **given birth** for him,
b but she had **a slave-girl, an Egyptian one**,
b' and her name was **Hagar** (= "The Immigrant").

² And **Sarai** said to **Avram**,
a "Look, please! Yahweh has restrained me from **giving birth** .
b Please, **go into** **my slave-girl** .
a' Perhaps I can be **built up** by means of her."

a ³ And **Sarai, the wife of Avram** **took** **Hagar, her Egyptian slave-girl** ,
b at the end of twenty years of Avram dwelling in the land of Canaan,
a' and **she** **gave** her to **Avram** her husband **as a wife** .

⁴ And **he went into** **Hagar** and she became **pregnant** ,
and she saw that she was **pregnant** ,
and her mistress **became cursed in her eyes** .

⁵ And Sarai said to Avram,
"May the violence done to me be upon you!
I gave **my slave-girl** into your lap,
and she saw that she became **pregnant** ,
and I **became cursed in her eyes** .
May Yahweh bring justice between me and between you!"

⁶ And Avram said to Sarai,
"Look, **your slave-girl** is in your hand;
do to her **what is good in your eyes**."
and Sarai **oppressed** her, and so she fled from before her face.

⁷ **And the messenger of Yahweh** found her,
at **a spring of waters** in the wilderness,
at **a spring** on the way to Shur,
⁸ **and he said**,
"**Hagar, slave-girl** of **Sarai**,
Where is it you come from?
And to where are you going?"
And she said,
"From before the face of **Sarai my mistress** I am fleeing."

⁹ **And the messenger of Yahweh said to her**,
"Return to **your mistress**,
and **oppress** yourself under her hand."

¹⁰ **And the messenger of Yahweh said to her**,
"**Multiplying I will multiply** your **seed**,
so it cannot be counted, because of its **multiplication**."

¹¹ **And the messenger of Yahweh said to her**,
"Look, you are **pregnant** and will **give birth to a son**,
and **you will call his name Yishmael (=El Will Hear)**
because Yahweh has heard your **oppression** .

¹² And as for him, he will be a donkey of a human.
His hand will be against everyone,
and everyone's hand will be against him.
And against the face of all his brothers he will reside."

¹³ And **she called the name** of Yahweh who spoke to her,
"You are **El-Roi (=El Who Sees Me)**
because she said,
"Have I also seen here the back of **the one who sees me** ?"

¹⁴ Therefore, **she called the well**,
Beer Lakhai-**Roi** (= " **Well** of the Living **One Who Sees Me.** ")
Look, it's between Qadesh and between Bered.

15 And Hagar **gave birth to a son** for Avram,
 and Avram **called the name of his son**,
 the one whom Hagar **birthed**, **Yishmael**
 16 Now, Avram was a son of eighty-six years,
 when Hagar **birthed** **Yishmael** for Avram.

Genesis 16:1-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The Crisis of God's Promise: No Seed

Now that the promises of both seed and land have been repeated to Avram (first in [Gen. 12](#), then [chapter 13](#), and again in [chapter 15](#)), the story returns its focus to the problem of Sarai's infertility introduced back in [Genesis 11:30](#): "And Sarai was infertile, and she had no child."

In contrast to [chapter 15](#), which focuses on Avram's struggle to trust God, [chapter 16](#) turns to Sarai's struggle.

The Hagar Incident and Genesis 1-6

Avram and Sarai acquired Egyptian plunder, including slaves, back in [Genesis 12:10-20](#), as a result of Avram's deception of Pharaoh. This plunder eventually divides the brothers, and Avram and Lot part ways because of too many possessions. Lot's settlement in Sodom leads to his capture in the flood-like battle of the kings. This entire sequence in Genesis 12-14 is set on analogy with Genesis 1-9, and so we expect the same here. This story in [Genesis 16](#) is riddled with allusions, wordplays, and hyperlinks to Genesis 2-9, all of which are crucial to interpreting of the story's details.

Hyperlinks to Genesis 2-3

Genesis 16:1-16	Genesis 2-3
Gen. 16:2 "Yahweh has restrained (עצר) me from giving birth." Gen. 16:10 "I will greatly multiply your seed (זרע)."	Gen. 2:18-25 Yahweh provides a woman for the human as a delivering-help (עזר), so that they can reproduce.
Gen. 16:2 "Go into my slave-girl, perhaps I can be built (בנה) from her."	Gen. 2:22 "and Yahweh built (בנה) the side which he had taken from the human into a woman."
Gen. 16:2b "and Avram listened to the voice of Sarai" (שמע + לקול)	Gen. 3:17 "because you listened to the voice of your wife" (שמע + לקול)
<i>Links Between Genesis 2-3 and 16. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

Genesis 16:1-16	Genesis 2-3
Gen. 16:3-3 "and Sarai took (ותקח) Hagar ... and she gave (ותתן) her to Avram her husband (אִישָׁהּ) as a wife (לְאִשָּׁה) ... And he went into her."	Gen. 3:6 "and the woman (הָאִשָּׁה) ... took (ותקח) the fruit ... and she gave (ותתן) also to her husband (לְאִישָׁהּ), and he ate."
Gen. 16:4 "and she [Hagar] saw that (ותרא כי) she was pregnant, and her master was cursed in her eyes (בעיניה)."	Gen. 3:6 "and the woman saw that (ותרא כי) the tree was good (טוב) for food, and desirable to the eyes " (לעֵינַיִם)
Gen. 16:6 "Avram said to Sarai, 'Behold, your slave-girl is in your hand , do to her what is good (טוב) in your eyes (בעיניך).'"	
Gen. 16:7 God visits Hagar by a spring of water in the wilderness	Gen. 3:8 God visits Adam and Eve by the tree in the middle of the garden (from which the river is sourced, see Gen. 2:10-14)
Gen. 16:8 "And [the angel] said to Hagar ... 'From where (אֵי מִזֶּה) have you come, and to where do you go?'"	Gen. 3:9 "And Yahweh God called to the human and said, ' Where are you (אֵיכָה)?'"
Gen. 16:10-11 "And the angel of Yahweh said to her [Hagar]: ' I will great multiply (הִרְבָּה אֲרַבָּה) your seed ... You are pregnant (הָרָה), will give birth (יֵלֵד) to a son.'"	Gen. 3:16 "To the woman he said, ' I will greatly multiply (הִרְבָּה אֲרַבָּה) your grief and pregnancy (הָרִינָךְ), and in grief you will give birth (יֵלֵד).'"
<i>Links Between Genesis 2-3 and 16. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

Analogies with Genesis 3 are dynamic in this story.

- Sarai and Eve: She doesn't trust the divine promise, so she comes up with an alternative plan to secure seed (זרע) for herself.
- Hagar and the tree of knowing good and bad: Hagar, through no fault of her own, was given to this family by Pharaoh, and now finds herself the object of desire for both Sarai (as a surrogate womb) and Avram (for sexual pleasure). Hagar's existence presents Avram and Sarai with a test of faith: Will they trust God to provide a child from their bodies or will they come up with their own plan to secure blessing and seed on their own?
- Avram and Adam: A passive, complicit figure who gets to benefit from the difficult situation of both women in this story.

Hyperlinks to Genesis 4

Genesis 16:1-16	Genesis 4
Gen. 16:3 “from the end of ten years (מקץ ... שנים) of Avram dwelling in the land” Gen. 16:4 “and he went into Hagar and she became pregnant”	Gen. 4:1 “And the human knew his wife and she became pregnant” Gen. 4:3 “and at the end of days (מקץ ימים)”
Gen. 16:4 “When [Hagar] saw that she was pregnant, her mistress became cursed in her eyes.”	Gen. 4:4-5 “and Yahweh gazed at Abel and his offering, but at Cain and his offering he did not gaze.”
Gen. 16:5 “May the violence done to me be upon you!” Gen. 16:6 “And Sarai oppressed her.”	Gen. 4:8 “and Cain rose up against Abel his brother, and he murdered him.”
Gen. 16:6-7 “and she fled from before her face, and a messenger of Yahweh found her”	Gen. 4:14 “you have banished me today ... and from before your face I will be hidden, and anyone who finds me will murder me!” Gen. 4:16 “and Cain went out from before the face of Yahweh”
Gen. 16:8 “From where (אי) are you coming, and to where do you go?”	Gen. 4:9 “Where (אי) is Abel your brother?”
Gen. 16:11 “You are pregnant and will give birth to a son and you will call his name Yishmael because Yahweh heard of your oppression.”	Gen. 4:10 “The sound of your brother’s blood is crying out to me.”
Gen. 16:12 “He will be a wild-donkey of a man, his hand against all ... and he will dwell against the face of his brothers”	Gen. 4:16 And Cain [the murderer of his brother] “went out ... and he dwelt in the land of wandering, east of Eden.”
<i>Links Between Genesis 4 and 16. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

While Avram and Sarai’s abuse of Hagar is portrayed on analogy to the folly of Adam and Eve in [Genesis 3](#), this story also portrays the division of Sarai and Hagar (rival wives) on analogy with the division of Cain and Abel (rival brothers). Notice how both sets of hyperlinks are overlaid and overlapping in the exact same story.

The story of the sibling rivalry in [Genesis 4](#) is here developed into a story of rival wives.

Hyperlinks to Genesis 6

Genesis 16	Genesis 6
Gen. 16:3-4 Of the covenant partners of Elohim, Sarai schemes to produce seed, so she “takes” (לקח) a wife (אשה) of her choosing for Avram.	Gen. 6:2 The sons of Elohim “see” (ראה) the daughters of humanity and “take” (לקח) for themselves whatever wives (אשה) they choose.
Gen. 16:4, 8-9 Sarai is called the “mistress” (גבירה, <i>gevirah</i>), feminine form of <i>gibbor</i> (גבור).	Gen. 6:4 "The Nephilim were in the land in those days, and also afterward, when the sons of Elohim went into the daughters of humanity, and they bore children for them; these are the mighty warriors (גבור, <i>gibbor</i>) who are from ancient time, men of the name."
Gen. 16:5 “May the violence (חמס) done to me be upon you!” Gen. 16:6 And she [= Sarai] oppressed her [= Hagar]	Gen. 6:11 “Now the land was ruined before God, and the land was filled with violence (חמס).”
Gen. 16:11 “Yahweh has heard your oppression.”	Gen. 6:13 “An end of all flesh has come up before me, because the land is filled with violence (חמס).”
Gen. 16:7, 14 Yahweh meets Hagar by a life-giving spring in the wilderness, called the “Well of the Life (חי) of My Seeing.”	Gen. 6:14, 19-20 God reveals the coming flood to Noah, and instructs him to build the ark, so he can keep alive (חיה) all flesh that comes to him.
<i>Links Between Genesis 6 and 16. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

Reflection Question

What words and themes link [Genesis 16:1-6](#) to [Genesis 3](#), [4](#), and [6](#)?